

Do you think this current system provides adequate accountability around short-term rentals in San Francisco? In your response, describe why you believe the system is adequate or inadequate. If you believe the system is inadequate, discuss a possible change in actions required to improve accountability in this system. You may refer to the SWE Code of Ethics as you think through your response.

I think currently there are some glaring issues with the system that is in place for specifically the accountability of the short term rentals in san francisco. Since these rentals are taking long term housing options off the market, they should be verified and regulated in order to make sure that enough people can permanently live in San Francisco as they want to. However through the project I learned that there are multiple instances where the policy numbers were not correct or missing. This is a worrying sign as if the units are not confirmed to be short term rentals people can game the system and worsen the housing situation even more than it already is. Also I feel like another major problem is that there are no government checks in order to make sure the listings are valid. Currently it is just a trust based system, with complaints being the only way to get any illegitimate houses off of the market. This is worrying for many reasons specifically in a market like San Fran which as mentioned earlier struggles with adequate housing. When referring to the SWE code of ethics, I think there is too much power being put in the hands of the Air B and B owners and not enough initiative on the back end to properly set up for a system of success.

As discussed in the introduction, the legality of web scraping is still uncertain in the US. Skim through the Legal Issues section of Web Scraping in the US on Wikipedia and this article about the legal issues with the Computer Fraud and Abuse Act, and describe at least one factor you believe is important to consider when discussing the legality of web scraping and why

"If you're not familiar with the CFAA, you may be wondering how is it possible that a law meant to target serious computer breaks-ins is being abused to target violations of websites' terms of service. The CFAA makes it a crime to "access a computer without authorization" or in a manner that "exceeds authorization." But the law doesn't make clear what these phrases mean." This is a direct quote from the Abuse Act article that I wanted to highlight. I think that it is really important to take into account the context behind the choices being made in these web scraping situations. Obviously web scraping for the context of a business or personal project probably does not have any ramifications because there is no clear harm being done. However, what if you were stealing data from users? Unfortunately there is no clear data to distinguish the two. I don't think all web scraping is malicious at all, in fact many businesses use this practice a lot to make their algorithms better and more advanced. I think the government should focus on fixing the dodgy wording behind the scenes when looking at legal violations.

Scraping public data does not always lead to positive results for society. For example, look to Facebook-Cambridge Analytica data scandal - Wikipedia or Clearview AI - Wikipedia. Many argue that using someone's personal data without their consent (even if publicly provided) is unethical.

Web scraping requires thoughtful intervention. Develop at least two guidelines you think are important to consider when deciding whether to do web scraping.

I think two important guidelines to think about when doing web scraping work is 1. What is the actual data that you are looking for and 2. What is the goal with the data? For the purposes of this specific project I would say that we passed both of these requirements. We were looking at listing data in static files and the purpose was to learn about data scraping as well as try and look deeper at the issue of the San Francisco housing market failures. However if there was somebody who went through a personal project where they were taking private data from users I would consider that to be unethical. At the same time if someone was taking meaningless data but somehow profiting off of it in an unethical way I would consider that a very bad use case of webscraping. Overall I think it just comes down to the ethics behind why and what you are doing with the data that is being scraped and most of the time those things are able to be determined from the project scope.